Before Something Happens

Care decisions for aging families

Quick Note Before You Start

This guide is meant for families who know a conversation is coming and want a better way to start it. Talking early about driving, support at home, legal planning, and housing options usually leads to calmer decisions than waiting for a crisis.

The National Institute on Aging says planning ahead allows families to make important decisions while the older adult is still able to participate clearly and express preferences. That is one reason these conversations matter before there is an emergency.

Important Note

This guide is for general educational purposes only. It is not medical, legal, financial, or emergency advice. It is designed to help families start conversations, notice changes, and think through next steps. Decisions about driving, care needs, legal documents, housing, and medical concerns should be made with the appropriate qualified professionals.

Why These Talks Matter

Proactive discussions about care needs and future plans can:

- Reduce stress and conflict during challenging times.
- Ensure your loved one's preferences are respected.
- Empower older adults to maintain control over their lives for as long as possible.
- Facilitate informed decision-making.
- Strengthen family bonds through open communication.

How to Start Better

Starting the conversation can feel daunting, but here are some tips:

- **Choose the right time and place:** Select a calm, comfortable environment where you can talk without distractions.
- **Express your love and concern:** Frame the conversation around your desire to support their well-being.
- **Listen actively:** Pay attention to their feelings and perspectives.
- **Be patient:** These conversations may take time and multiple discussions.
- **Focus on solutions, not problems:** Approach the conversation with a collaborative mindset.

Driving

Driving is often tied to independence, making discussions about driving safety emotional. It's important to approach this topic with sensitivity and understanding.

Consider:

- **Self-assessment:** Encourage your loved one to reflect on their driving abilities.
- **Professional evaluation:** Consult with a driving rehabilitation specialist for an objective assessment.
- **Alternative transportation:** Explore options such as ride-sharing services, public transportation, or family support.

If you have concerns about an unsafe driver in Utah, you can submit a report to the Utah Driver License Division. The report must be notarized and may lead to a review, knowledge test, vision exam, skills test, or medical forms.

When More Help Is Needed at Home

Recognizing the need for additional support at home is a crucial step in ensuring your loved one's safety and well-being.

Signs that more help may be needed include:

- Difficulty with daily tasks such as bathing, dressing, or meal preparation.
- Increased falls or accidents.
- Memory problems or confusion.
- Neglecting household chores or personal hygiene.

Care Options to Discuss

Care Option	Description
Homemaker Services	Help with chores, errands, and meal preparation.
Home Health Care	Skilled nursing care, physical therapy, or occupational therapy provided in the home.
Personal Care	Assistance with bathing, dressing, and grooming.
Transportation	Help getting to appointments, errands, or social activities.
Companionship	Social interaction and emotional support.
Respite Care	Temporary relief for family caregivers.

Assisted Living and Leaving Home

The need to move to assisted living can be hard. These residences offer a supportive environment for individuals who require assistance with daily living activities but do not need the intensive medical care provided in a nursing home.

Consider:

- **Visiting several communities:** Schedule tours to assess the facilities, amenities, and staff.
- **Talking to residents:** Ask about their experiences and satisfaction with the community.
- **Evaluating the level of care:** Ensure the community can meet your loved one's specific needs.
- **Understanding the costs:** Determine the payment options and financial assistance available.

Decision-Making and Point of Contact

Designating a point of contact ensures clear communication and streamlined decision-making during emergencies or critical situations. This person will serve as the primary liaison between family members, healthcare providers, and other relevant parties.

Important Considerations:

- **Choose a Trusted Individual:** Select someone who is responsible, organized, and able to handle stressful situations.
- **Ensure Willingness:** Confirm that the chosen individual is willing and able to take on this responsibility.

- **Clearly Define Roles:** Outline the specific responsibilities of the point of contact, such as communicating updates, coordinating appointments, and making decisions on behalf of your loved one.

Power of Attorney and Other Planning

Legal and financial planning are essential components of preparing for the future. Key documents to consider include:

- **Financial Power of Attorney:** Grants someone the authority to manage your finances if you become unable to do so.
- **Healthcare Power of Attorney (Medical Decision Maker):** Designates someone to make healthcare decisions on your behalf.
- **Advance Directive (Living Will):** Outlines your wishes regarding medical treatment in the event you are unable to communicate.
- **HIPAA Releases:** Authorizes healthcare providers to share your medical information with designated individuals.
- **Important Documents:** Keep IDs, insurance cards, medication lists, and the location of your will/trust readily accessible.

"Planning ahead helps families make important decisions while the older adult can still participate."

Other Topics Worth Covering

While discussing the topics outlined above, consider addressing these additional areas:

- **Financial resources and planning:** Understand your loved one's financial situation and explore options for managing expenses.
- **End-of-life wishes:** Discuss preferences for hospice care, funeral arrangements, and memorial services.
- **Social support and engagement:** Encourage your loved one to maintain social connections and participate in activities they enjoy.

Simple Conversation Starter Checklist

Use this simple checklist to get started. Remember to be patient, listen, and show your support:

- [ ] Schedule a dedicated time to talk.
- [ ] Express your love and concern.
- [ ] Ask open-ended questions.
- [ ] Listen actively to their responses.
- [ ] Take notes and summarize key points.
- [ ] Schedule a follow-up conversation.

About Red Desert Check-In

Red Desert Check-In provides in-person check-ins for aging adults who are still living independently. During visits, we look for practical changes families may not always see right away, including home safety concerns, food, mobility, routine, and general well-being.

After each visit, family receives a clear update. When concerns show up, we can also help point families toward trusted local connections for next steps.

This is not medical care, emergency response, or full-time caregiving. It is an extra set of eyes during the in-between stage.

Take the Next Step

Use this guide as a starting point for family conversations. If something brings up a concern, reach out and we can talk through what you are noticing and what local next steps may make sense.

Source Notes

- **National Institute on Aging:** www.nia.nih.gov (Aging in Place, Care Planning)
- **Utah Driver License Division:** dld.utah.gov (Unsafe Driver Reporting)
- **Medicare:** www.medicare.gov (Long-Term Care Coverage)